

Flightless Fancy

A former medical practitioner sees emu farming as a new field of opportunity for poverty-stricken Orissa



REDDY AT HIS FARM

By Farzand Ahmed

For a rural medical practitioner from the interior of Orissa's Ganjam district bordering Andhra Pradesh, the sight of huge flightless birds on a visit to Hyderabad in 2005 was a life-changing event. It was love at first sight for 48-year-old D. Mohan Reddy, who saw an immediate career change and, sure enough, the birds soon laid the proverbial golden eggs for him; only these were big and dark green. Back home in Pitatali village under Chikati block, about 30 km east of Berhampur, Reddy set up a 100-acre farm and brought in a few pairs of emus. Four years later, Reddy's farm is teaming with 65 of these big, brown birds, that are next only to ostriches and cassowaries in size and weight.

Emus belong to the ostrich family and are native to Australia. They can travel great distances and sprint up to 50 km/hr. Rising up to 2 m, or 6.6 ft, and weighing up to 60 kg, these birds have a lifespan of 40 years. A female emu lays 20-25 eggs in a season (October-March). The male incubates the eggs for eight weeks, hardly eating or drinking during this period and losing about a third of his body weight. Reddy has set up incubators and hatching now takes only a week. "I have a

passion for these birds. Every morning and evening I personally feed them maize and wheat and spend some time with them in the farm," says Reddy. After having learnt the know-how of emu farming in neighbouring Hyderabad and Rajahmundry and the successful experiment in his village, he wants to popularise emu farming in poverty-stricken Orissa.

Emus are unique in a sense that they are no-risk, no-disease birds with high commercial value: A two-month-old chick fetches Rs 6,000 and an egg weighing up to 800 gm costs Rs 2,500. "It's a very powerful, natural aphrodisiac, more effective than Viagra," laughs Reddy. Emu meat is 98 per cent fat-free with low cholesterol content. It is also rich in protein and iron. Reddy points out that the oil obtained from fat from the upper back of the bird is in high demand for making medicines and cosmetics. Its application, he says, reverses signs of ageing and provides relief from body pain and aches. Reddy has a buy-back arrangement with firms in Dindigul in Tamil Nadu, Hyderabad and Vijayawada to minimise losses.

Emus, it seems, have made this quack wiser, who has now become a source of inspiration for others. ■